BUSINESS INSIGHTS REPORT · RETAIL BANKING

Sentiment Analysis of Retail Banking Customer Feedback
Channel, Driver and Segment Comparisons

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Source tool	Retail Banking Sentiment Analysis Dashboard — Streamlit + TextBlob (github.com/tshepisofrominnostation/banking-sentiment-dashboard)
Dataset	41 customer reviews, Sep–Oct 2026, four channels: Banking App, Instant EFT, Branch, Card/ATM
Method	TextBlob polarity scoring, thresholds: Positive > +0.1, Negative < −0.1, else Neutral
Date	16 October 2026

1 Executive Summary

This report converts 41 raw customer reviews from the bank's four retail channels into measurable sentiment findings using the sentiment dashboard tool. Every number below is computed by the tool, not estimated.

Overall the customer base leans **negative: 51.2% of reviews score negative** against 34.1% positive (average polarity −0.108). The three most important findings:

Finding 1 — The app is the weakest channel. Banking App reviews are 61.5% negative, the worst rate of any channel, and app-stability complaints (crashes tied to load shedding windows) are the single largest driver of negative sentiment bank-wide (6 of 21 negative reviews, 28.6%).

Finding 2 — Card/ATM has the most severe sentiment. Although the App has the highest negative share, Card/ATM has the lowest average polarity (−0.218), driven by card retention incidents and cash-out outages on paydays.

Finding 3 — Digital-heavy segments are the unhappiest. Young Professionals (71.4% negative) and Families (70.0%) are far more dissatisfied than Small Business clients (25.0%, average polarity +0.301) — the dissatisfaction is concentrated where the bank is most digital.

41	34.1%	51.2%	−0.108
TOTAL REVIEWS	POSITIVE	NEGATIVE	AVG POLARITY

2 Sentiment Breakdown

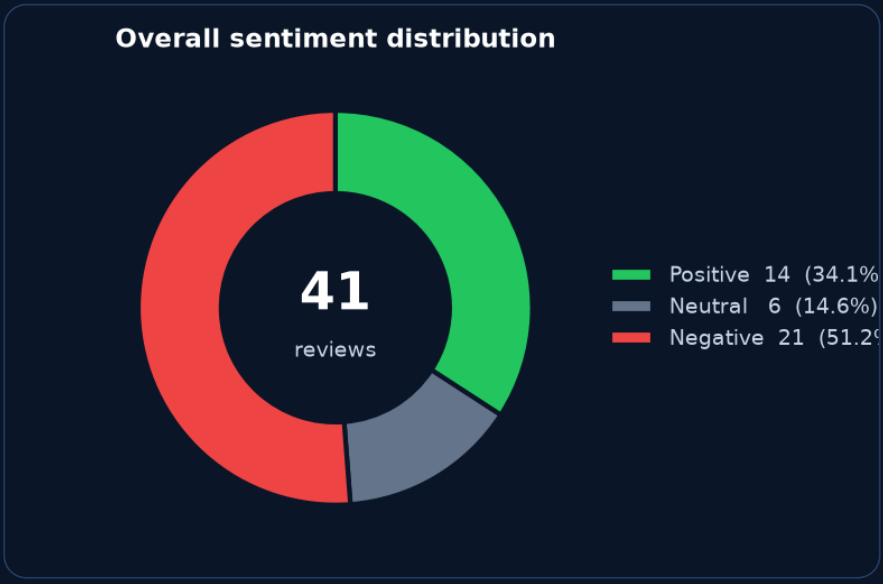


Figure 1 — Overall sentiment distribution across all 41 reviews (TextBlob polarity, ±0.1 thresholds).

The negative majority (21 of 41 reviews) is not evenly spread — the next section compares channels to show where it concentrates. Only 6 reviews are genuinely neutral (factual statements with no sentiment-bearing language); the bank is generating strong reactions, both good and bad, from most customers.

3 Channel Comparison — Where the Pain Sits

CHANNEL	REVIEWS	POSITIVE	NEUTRAL	NEGATIVE	% NEGATIVE	% POSITIVE	AVG POLARITY
Banking App	13	3	2	8	61.5%	23.1%	−0.186
Card/ATM	9	3	1	5	55.6%	33.3%	**−0.218**
Instant EFT	10	4	1	5	50.0%	40.0%	+0.030
Branch	9	4	2	3	33.3%	44.4%	−0.038

Shaded rows: red = weakest channel by negative share; green = strongest channel. Avg polarity: mean TextBlob compound score per channel.

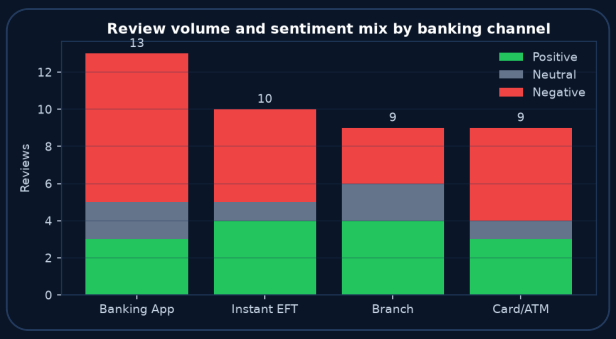


Figure 2 — Review volume and sentiment mix by channel.

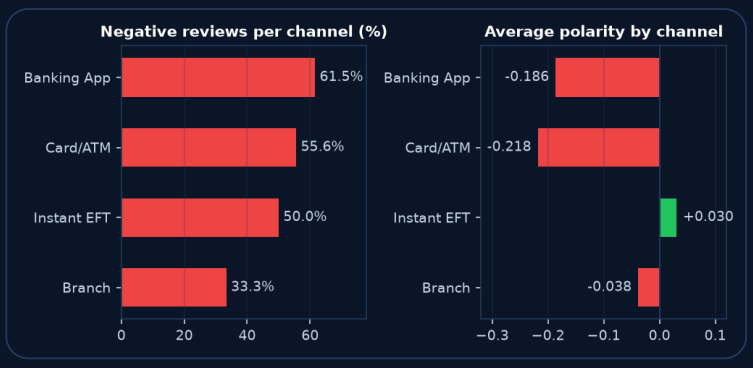


Figure 3 — Side-by-side comparison: negative share vs average polarity.

Reading the comparison

Banking App vs Branch is the starkest contrast: the App is 61.5% negative while the Branch is 44.4% positive — a 28-percentage-point gap in negative share between the bank's most digital and most human channels. The App also receives the highest review volume (13 of 41, 32% of all feedback), so its problems dominate the overall numbers.

Card/ATM: low volume, high severity. Its negative share (55.6%) is second, but its average polarity (−0.218) is the lowest of all channels — when ATM customers complain, they complain severely (retained cards, cash-out outages on payday). This matters for a low-volume channel: each incident hits a customer at a critical moment (payday, pension draw).

Instant EFT is the quiet middle. 50% negative but positive-leaning average polarity (+0.030): the half that works, works well ("money arrived instantly"); the complaints are concentrated in overnight settlement delays and low limits.

Positive counterweights

The 14 positive reviews cluster around three strengths the bank should protect: **branch staff quality** ("Opened a business account in one visit, the consultant knew his products inside out" — R031, polarity +1.0), **app reliability when it works** ("Biometric login works flawlessly and the notifications are instant" — R006, +0.67), and **innovative self-service** ("Cardless cash withdrawal worked first time at the ATM. Wonderful." — R017, +0.62).

4 Root Cause Analysis — What Drives the Negativity

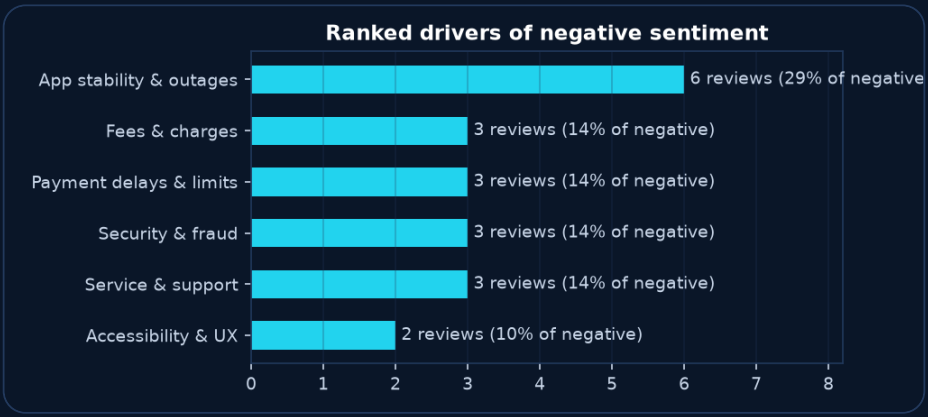


Figure 4 — Ranked drivers of negative sentiment: theme counts across the 21 negative reviews (keyword-matched by the tool).

RANK	DRIVER	REVIEWS	% OF NEGATIVE	REPRESENTATIVE EVIDENCE (VERBATIM)
1	App stability & outages	6	28.6%	"The app crashed twice during load shedding while I was paying my exam fees."
2	Fees & charges	3	14.3%	"Fees went up again without any warning. This feels dishonest."
2	Payment delays & limits	3	14.3%	"My instant EFT sat pending overnight and no one could tell me why."
2	Security & fraud	3	14.3%	"The ATM kept my card on payday and I had to order a replacement."
2	Service & support	3	14.3%	"Queued for 45 minutes at month end just to draw my pension."
6	Accessibility & UX	2	9.5%	"The statements are hard to read… small text for older eyes."

5 Customer Segment Comparison

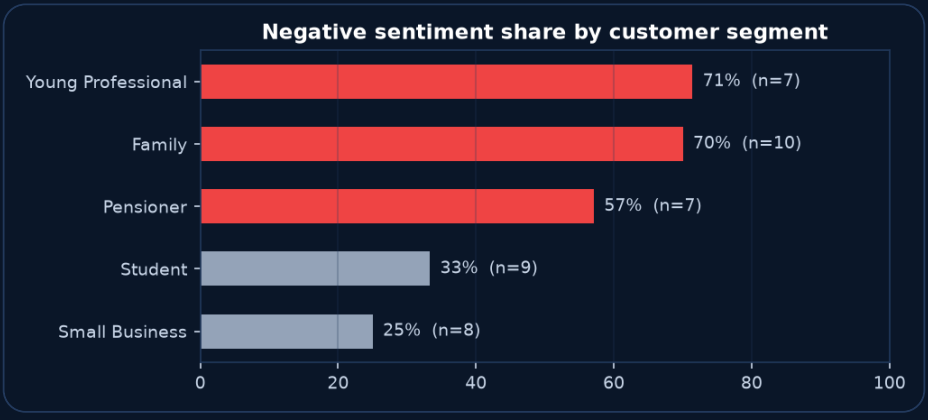


Figure 5 — Negative sentiment share by customer segment (n = reviews per segment).

The digital divide is generational. Young Professionals (71.4% negative, avg polarity −0.338) and Families (70.0%) are the unhappiest segments — both are heavy app and EFT users, so they absorb the App's stability problems directly. Small Business clients are the happiest (25.0% negative, avg +0.301), and their praise centres on branch consulting and same-day batch payments. Pensioners (57.1% negative) complain about branch queues and ATM card retention, not digital issues.

6 Strategic Recommendations

Each recommendation states the finding it comes from (with its number), the action, and the metric to track.

1 Stand up a joint tech-and-ops task force to triage banking app complaints.

From Finding 1: the App is the weakest channel (61.5% negative, 13 reviews) with the highest feedback volume. A weekly cross-functional review of app complaints shortens the loop between complaint and fix.

Metric: % negative Banking App reviews, tracked weekly (baseline 61.5%)

2 Add load-shedding resilience testing to the app release cycle and publish outage alerts in-app.

From Finding 1 + Section 4: app stability is the #1 driver (6 of 21 negative reviews, 28.6%) and the evidence ties crashes to load shedding windows. Customers lost money-moment access (exam fees, data purchases) during outages.

Metric: App crash complaints per 1,000 active users (baseline: 28.6% of negative reviews)

3 Commit to a same-day EFT settlement SLA and proactive fee-change notifications 30 days ahead.

From Section 4: overnight EFT delays (14.3% of negatives) and unexpected fee increases (14.3%) are trust destroyers for digital-heavy segments (Young Professionals 71.4% negative). Clear the overnight backlog and remove the surprise.

Metrics: median EFT settlement time (hours) · fee-related complaints per month

4 Target Card/ATM incidents on paydays: predictive cash replenishment and card-retention reviews.

From Finding 2: Card/ATM has the lowest average polarity (−0.218) though only 9 reviews; incidents cluster on paydays and pension days (card retention, cash outages), hitting Pensioners (57.1% negative) hardest.

Metric: Card retention incidents and cash-out outages per 1,000 ATM transactions, month-end vs baseline

7 Methodology & Limitations

Method: 41 reviews (bundled demonstration dataset representative of SA retail banking feedback, Sep–Oct 2026) were ingested, preprocessed (lowercasing, URL and special-character removal via regex) and scored with TextBlob polarity/subjectivity. Sentiment thresholds: Positive > +0.1, Negative < −0.1, Neutral otherwise. Negative drivers were identified by keyword-theme matching across negative reviews. All figures were produced by the dashboard tool's analysis functions on 16 October 2026.

Limitations: (1) 41 reviews is a small sample — percentages carry wide confidence intervals and should be read as directional. (2) Lexicon-based scoring (TextBlob) misses sarcasm and SA slang, and can underweight words like "furious" or "unacceptable" that its lexicon does not score. (3) Theme matching is keyword-based; a review can carry multiple themes or none. (4) The dataset is a realistic demonstration set, not live production feedback. Recommended next step: re-run on live complaint exports and 500+ reviews, and pilot an LLM-based classifier for comparison against the TextBlob baseline.

Verbatim evidence — most extreme reviews

MOST NEGATIVE

> "Queued for 45 minutes at month end just to draw my pension. Terrible experience." — R004, Branch, polarity −1.0

> "The ATM kept my card on payday and I had to order a replacement. Disgusted." — R021, Card/ATM, polarity −1.0

> "The app crashed twice during load shedding while I was paying my exam fees." — R034, Banking App, polarity −1.0

MOST POSITIVE

> "Opened a business account in one visit, the consultant knew his products inside out." — R031, Branch, polarity +1.0

> "Biometric login works flawlessly and the notifications are instant. Very impressed." — R006, Banking App, polarity +0.67

> "Cardless cash withdrawal worked first time at the ATM. Wonderful." — R017, Card/ATM, polarity +0.62